[EDWARD BURGESS TO MRS. HENRY BURGESS] *Tabreez, August 3, 1844*

I received yours of the 4th June last night, many thanks for it. It is a letter full of questions and therefore an easy one to answer. I am very glad indeed that the Persian dance amused you. First as to the word Moslem is I believe a corruption of "Muslim" which means the same as "Musulmān," one who receives the true faith or "islām." Richardson also says that it means obedience to the true faith or written word of God. I do not think it can mean *blind obedience,* because the Mahomedans say that when a man comes to years of discretion it is his duty to learn, and enquire, whether his faith is the true one or not. And that if he receives his faith merely because his father and his mother received it before him, he is little better than an infidel.[73] This is the opinion of many of the most learned Mahomedan divines, particularly amongst this sect, Sheeah. But whether the opinion is very general or not I do not know.

Now for the affairs of the villages, they thank God go on remarkably well. The cotton cultivation will be I believe nearly doubled and the grain is a very abundant crop, so I hope to make something this year and if you knew what work I have had you would say that I deserve any thing I can make. I believe that I told you that there were a number of soldiers of different sorts, cavalry, infantry and artillery, but I do not know whether I told you that there are two officers amongst them, a captain of cavalry and a lieutenant of infantry. The captain is an elderly, and as far as I have yet seen, a very respectable man, who thinks much more about farming than fighting. Last year I was of some little service to him in the matter of getting him a part of his pay which his colonel seemed incline to plunder him of. But the lieutenant who is a young fellow of two or three and twenty, is perhaps as great a scamp as ever took a moonlight leap over the border. Last winter I was obliged to get him rather severely punished, for turning out his soldiers and making a riot in the village, and disobeying a written order which he tore up before all the people and abused the writer. I was sorry for him because he is a very dashing fellow, and he was exceedingly civil when I was in the village last year: and the order altho' about my affairs was not written by me. However I gave him a few yards of blue cotton stuff to make a coat of, which he dignified with the name of a dress of honor, and we were better friends than ever.

Last winter a Captain who lives in a neighbouring village had come with a party of men, and driven off some sheep belonging to our village the Lieut. heard of it mounted his horse armed with sword and spear, and accompanied by three or four horsemen chased the captain and overtook him, just as he and his party were driving the sheep into their own village. He charged the captain,

[73] E. B.'s explanation is essentially the opinion of both sects of Islam.

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